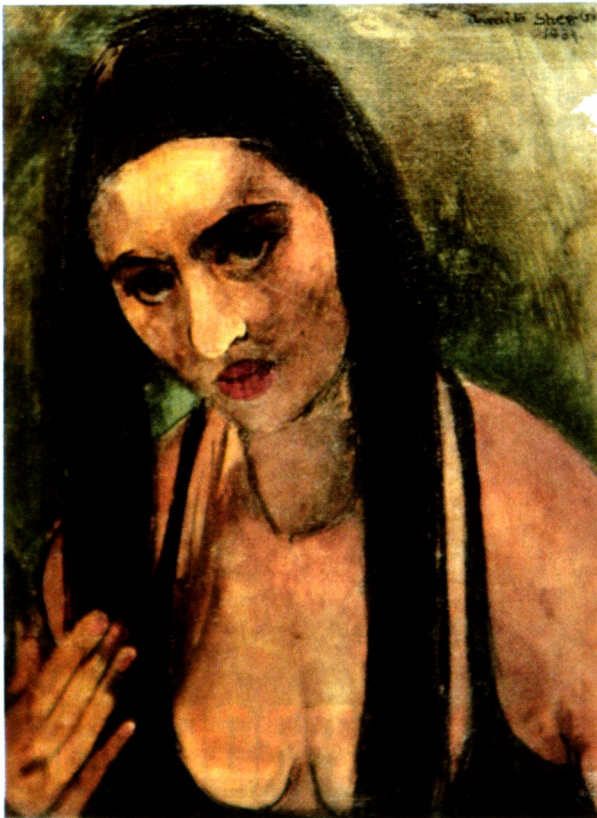




HER SELF-PORTRAIT WITH LONG HAIR (2), 1934

good use, making close studies of the woman folk and their cloistered existence, many of whom she bonds with. Her husband, a doctor by profession, was later to return here after her death and immerse himself in helping the village folk, filling a much needed lacuna in medical care.

While speculations continue about the causes for the artist's sudden death which cannot be answered conclusively, the fact remains that she is sorely missed by her relatives, the art community and the world at large. While the artistic merit of the paintings are viewed with some reservations, many have savoured their sensuous grace at the National Gallery of Modern Art, where the initial collection was generously donated by her late husband Egan after her death.

While working on Sher-Gil's biography a few years ago, I came across a letter written by the distraught Umrao Singh, her father, who when Indira's son and her nephew Sundaram was born, two years after her death, comforted himself by feeling that it was Sher-Gil herself reborn and that the child would be a painter. Reincarnation or not, the artistic eye and diligence which Sundaram has brought to these volumes makes for a moving tribute to the woman he has lived with all his life but never met. ■

Stale Story

A fictional subterfuge on a veteran foreign correspondent based in India

By Dilip Bobb



HINDUTVA, SEX AND ADVENTURE

by JOHN MACLITHON
Indialink

Price: Rs 195

Pages: 166

I have two reservations when it comes to books. If the word "sex" appears in the title, it's usually done to con some sucker into buying the book. The second is when the author hides behind a pseudonym. This is a novel, not some scoop that will change the course of history. There is a reason for the literary subterfuge. The novel is about a foreign correspondent based in India and is written by a foreign correspondent based in India. Essentially, it boils down to a

guessing game; which real life journo is the protagonist based on and who is John MacLithon?

Both questions are inconsequential to the average reader since there is such limited literary reward that interest will be restricted to the types who populate the bar at the Foreign Correspondents' Club in Delhi. That's a pretty small audience but then it's a pretty small-minded effort. The book is so obviously based on Mark Tully, the ex-BBC bureau chief and media star who spent almost his entire career in India, covering the region. He retired to write books and return to his radio days in a more spiritual avatar. The author does not even bother to disguise the parallels. Andrew (the protagonist), like Tully, has an India connection, is first drawn to the Church before switching to a career in a British news broadcasting company. He moves to Delhi, settles in East Nizamuddin, covers the epochal events of the last few decades in South Asia—Kashmir, Ayodhya, the Golden Temple, riots and disasters, gets connected with the usual suspects—right-wing fanatics, the Dalai Lama, Benazir Bhutto, Indian prime ministers, and, lest we forget the sex, an Indian journalist, before becoming famous and then, eventually quitting his job to settle down with a "partner" to write books which go soft on Hindutva and Hinduism.

Why the subterfuge when it's such an accurate mirror of Tully's life and career (minus the sex, of course) is anybody's guess. So is the identity of the author, obviously someone who has served for many years as a foreign journalist in Delhi, and, here's the Breaking News, now writes books! This is pretty shallow stuff in literary terms. It's also not difficult to guess the name of the author but that would have been worth it if the book was. It isn't. ■